HOW KIDS EAT

A Thanksgiving Nature Documentary

Written and directed by Amanda Young for ACS

A play in six specimens

Sixth Grade Thanksgiving Program

Running time, about 12 minutes

Cast of 12 or more

CAST

NARRATOR 1	*clipboard, safari hat, very serious*
NARRATOR 2	*the same, but more dramatic*
SIGN KID	*holds up the title cards, never speaks*
PEA KID	*the smuggler*
NOODLE KID	*the surgeon*
ARCHITECT	*nothing may touch*
THE MIXER	*everything must touch*
SHOVEL KID	*rice and gravy, at speed*
NEGOTIATOR	*will not eat, will bargain*
MOM	*patient, undefeated*
SLOW KID	*on bite one the entire play*
THE DOG	*a kid in dog ears, under the table*
EXTRAS	*as many as you have, seated at the table*

THE SET

One long table facing the audience, with the chairs behind it so the audience sees every plate. A fake plant off to one side. The Dog lives under the table and pops up when needed.

STAGING NOTES

- Keep everything turned out toward the audience. If the audience cannot see the plate, the joke is gone.
- Use safe stand-in food. Real dry rice, plastic peas, plain cooked noodles. Nobody actually eats on stage.
- Put a tarp or an old sheet under Shovel Kid.
- Slow Kid should be on stage before the lights come up and should still be there at the blackout.
- The narrators carry the show. Cast two kids who can keep a straight face.

OPENING

THE TABLE

(Narrators enter from opposite sides. Slow Kid is already at the table, fork raised, absolutely motionless.)

NARRATOR 1. *(hushed)* The fourth Thursday of November. A rare and dangerous day.

NARRATOR 2. Today, we observe the North American Sixth Grader as it approaches the most feared event of its year.

BOTH. Thanksgiving dinner.

SPECIMEN ONE · THE SMUGGLER

SPECIMEN ONE

THE PEAS

(Pea Kid enters, sits, looks at the plate, and freezes in horror.)

NARRATOR 1. The subject has encountered peas.

PEA KID. *(to the peas)* We meet again.

NARRATOR 2. It cannot eat them. It cannot leave. So it does what its species does best.

NARRATOR 1. It relocates.

(What follows is silent, and Pea Kid checks over both shoulders before every move. The narrators call it like a golf tournament.)

NARRATOR 2. *(whisper)* Into the milk.

(Pea Kid drops peas into the glass. Looks pleased. Then notices the milk is now green. Slides the glass toward a neighbor.)

NARRATOR 1. Bold.

NARRATOR 2. Into the mashed potatoes.

(Pea Kid buries a spoonful, pats it smooth like a tiny grave, and makes a small sad face.)

NARRATOR 1. Into the plant.

(Pea Kid stretches way out, dumps peas into the plant, and sits back innocently.)

NARRATOR 2. Into the sock.

NARRATOR 1. *(genuinely concerned)* Into the sock?

(Pea Kid lifts one leg onto the chair and pours peas in. Sits back. Nods.)

NARRATOR 2. And finally, the oldest partnership in nature.

(Pea Kid slowly lowers a hand under the table. The Dog's head pops up, eats, and disappears.)

PEA KID. *(patting the dog)* Good boy. You're the only one who gets me.

(Pea Kid holds up the empty plate proudly, stands to leave, and peas pour out of the napkin, the sleeve, the sock, everywhere. Long pause.)

PEA KID. . . . I'll get those later.

(Exits.)

SPECIMEN TWO · THE SURGEON

SPECIMEN TWO

THE FETTUCCINE

(Noodle Kid enters with a plate, sits, and lays out a napkin like a tray of surgical tools.)

NARRATOR 1. The subject has been served fettuccine.

NOODLE KID. Scalpel.

NARRATOR 2. It has not been served fettuccine. It has been served a problem.

(Noodle Kid begins removing things one at a time, holding each one up to the light, then setting it on the napkin.)

NOODLE KID. Green thing. *(sets it down)* Green thing. Green speck. Suspicious green speck. *(squints)* Mushroom. In my HOUSE.

NARRATOR 1. Note the precision. Not one flake of parsley will survive.

(Noodle Kid starts wiping the sauce off the noodles one at a time and lining them up in a row.)

NARRATOR 2. It has now removed the sauce.

NARRATOR 1. The sauce is the food.

NARRATOR 2. Not to this one.

(Noodle Kid finishes and holds up a plate with about four bare noodles on it. Beams.)

NOODLE KID. Perfect. *(eats one noodle, pushes the plate away)* I'm full.

NARRATOR 1. Eleven minutes of work.

NARRATOR 2. One noodle.

(Exits, leaving behind a napkin piled with the entire meal.)

SPECIMEN THREE · THE ARCHITECT

SPECIMEN THREE

NOTHING MAY TOUCH

(Architect enters, sits, and immediately begins engineering. Very calm, very focused.)

NARRATOR 1. Some subjects cannot tolerate contact between foods.

(Architect builds a mashed potato wall around the gravy, pats it firm, tests it, and adds height.)

NARRATOR 2. The potato levee. Passed down for generations.

(A cranberry rolls slowly across the plate and touches the turkey. Architect stares in silent horror.)

ARCHITECT. *(quiet, shaking)* It touched.

NARRATOR 1. Contact.

ARCHITECT. *(standing, to the whole table)* IT TOUCHED.

NARRATOR 2. The plate is now considered contaminated and will be abandoned.

(Architect slides the plate away with one finger and exits with great dignity.)

SPECIMEN FOUR · THE MIXER

SPECIMEN FOUR

EVERYTHING MUST TOUCH

(The Mixer enters, sees the abandoned plate, pulls it over, and begins mashing everything together with a spoon, humming happily.)

NARRATOR 1. In the very same habitat, the exact opposite creature.

(The Mixer adds turkey, stuffing, cranberry, gravy, corn. Stirs. Considers. Adds a roll. Stirs.)

NARRATOR 2. It's all going the same place.

THE MIXER. *(to the audience, mouth full)* It's all going the same place!

(The Mixer reaches over and dumps a slice of pie in. Both narrators react.)

NARRATOR 1. No.

NARRATOR 2. He wouldn't.

THE MIXER. *(stirring the pie in)* Trust me.

(Eats a huge bite. Closes both eyes. Absolutely transcendent.)

THE MIXER. Thanksgiving soup.

(Exits.)

SPECIMEN FIVE · THE VACUUM

SPECIMEN FIVE

RICE AND GRAVY

(Shovel Kid enters at a sprint with a heaping plate of rice and gravy, and sits.)

NARRATOR 1. Rice and gravy.

NARRATOR 2. Brace yourself.

(Shovel Kid eats like the plate is about to be taken away. No pauses. No breathing. Rice goes everywhere, the table, the floor, the hair, one grain on the forehead. Shovel Kid runs a hand through the hair and makes it worse.)

NARRATOR 1. No chewing has been observed.

NARRATOR 2. He is not tasting it. He is storing it.

(Shovel Kid finishes, sits back, completely covered, and totally serene.)

SHOVEL KID. *(polite, gravy on the face, a grain of rice on the forehead)* May I please be excused?

NARRATOR 1. Note the excellent manners.

NARRATOR 2. Note the ceiling.

(Everyone at the table looks up slowly. Shovel Kid exits.)

SPECIMEN SIX · THE NEGOTIATOR

SPECIMEN SIX

THE NEGOTIATOR

(Negotiator sits with both arms folded. Mom stands over the chair.)

MOM. Three bites.

NEGOTIATOR. One bite.

MOM. Three.

NEGOTIATOR. One bite, and I'll be nice to my sister for a week.

MOM. Two bites.

NEGOTIATOR. A lick.

MOM. What?

NEGOTIATOR. I'll lick it. Then technically I tried it.

NARRATOR 1. The subject has not eaten anything in four hundred years.

MOM. You have never even tasted a sweet potato.

NEGOTIATOR. And that is how I know I don't like it.

NARRATOR 2. Flawless logic.

MOM. One bite. Final offer.

(Negotiator takes the tiniest possible bite. Chews forever. Grimaces. Then stops. Considers. Takes another. Then eats the whole thing fast.)

NEGOTIATOR. *(mouth full, defensive)* This doesn't mean anything.

(Mom exits victorious.)

THE FINALE

FINALE

PIE

(Everyone drifts back to the table, groaning, stuffed, draped over the chairs. Slow Kid is still there, still on bite one.)

PEA KID. I'm so full.

NOODLE KID. I can't move.

SHOVEL KID. I may never eat again.

ARCHITECT. I'm never eating again in my whole life.

NARRATOR 1. The herd has reached capacity. There is no room left.

NARRATOR 2. None whatsoever.

(Mom enters carrying a pie.)

MOM. Who wants dessert?

(Everyone snaps upright at once. Plates out, hands up, total chaos.)

ALL. ME!

NARRATOR 1. Fascinating.

NARRATOR 2. Scientists remain baffled.

(Freeze. The narrators step forward.)

NARRATOR 1. They will not eat their vegetables.

NARRATOR 2. They will not let their food touch.

NARRATOR 1. They will hide peas in a sock.

NARRATOR 2. But they show up. Every single year. To the same table. With the same people.

NARRATOR 1. *(dropping the documentary voice)* And that is kind of the whole point.

NARRATOR 2. Happy Thanksgiving.

(Everyone dives for the pie. Blackout. In the dark, one loud crunch from Slow Kid.)

SLOW KID. *(in the dark)* I'm still on my first bite.

E N D

MORE BITS YOU CAN SWAP IN

Every scene in this play stands on its own, so bits can be cut, added, or reordered to fit the class. Here are more, sorted by the kind of kid who should play them.

PHYSICAL ONES, FOR THE FUNNIEST KIDS

The Roll Hoarder. Only eats dinner rolls. Takes eleven of them. Builds a pyramid. Guards it. Growls at anyone who reaches.

The Corn Typewriter. Eats corn on the cob in fast rows, dings at the end of each line, slides back to the start.

The Chipmunk. Stores everything in both cheeks so the plate looks empty, and then an adult asks a question.

The Milk Washer. One bite of turkey, one entire glass of milk. Repeat. Six refills, one piece of turkey.

Volcano Potatoes. Spends the whole meal sculpting a mashed potato volcano with a gravy crater, never eats a bite, and presents it like a science fair project.

TALKY ONES, FOR CONFIDENT READERS

The Food Critic. A sixth grader with a fake accent reviewing Grandma's stuffing. "The texture is bold. Perhaps too bold."

The Kids' Table Escape. One kid keeps sneaking toward the adult table and keeps getting sent back. A good runner through the whole show.

What Is It. "What's this?" "Green bean casserole." "What's in it?" "Green beans." "What ELSE?" "Beans, and a casserole." "I'm going to need a full ingredient list."

The Talker. Tells one endless story with a fork held in the air and never takes a single bite. Everyone else finishes and leaves. Still talking.

TEAM BITS

The Dog Union. Three different kids sneak food to the dog, none of them knowing about the others. The dog staggers out at the end and somebody says the dog looks bigger.

The Bathroom Ferry. A kid asks to go to the bathroom holding a suspiciously full napkin. Asks again. And again. The fourth time, Mom just holds out a hand and the napkin is surrendered.

The Saver. Saves the best bite for last, sets it aside carefully, describes how good it is going to be, turns away for two seconds, and somebody eats it. Big slow motion NOOOO.

RUNNING GAGS TO THREAD THROUGH

Slow Kid, still on bite one, in every single scene. It pays off in the blackout.

The Dog popping up under the table whenever a plate gets desperate.

Sign Kid's title cards, and one card that is clearly wrong so Sign Kid has to flip it around.

The green milk glass from the first scene, slid quietly down the table all night, until somebody finally drinks it.